

The Power of Attraction in Imam Ali (A.S.)

Reflections on Ayatullah Murtadha Mutahhari's
Polarization Around the Character of Imam 'Ali

Seyed Mohammad Abuzar Hashemi

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“Not a single atom of the world of existence is outside the governance of general attraction.”

— Mutahhari

- Every atom obeys attraction — ancients only saw *particular* cases (magnet–iron)
- No two people are close without a hidden “why” — resemblance or opposition
- Four kinds of people: rock · hypocrite · thorn · both
- 'Ali: one man, two powers — unmatched attraction *and* repulsion

Example — Rumi’s raven and stork: A wise man discovers the secret bond between two unlike birds — both are lame in one leg.

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└─Recap

└─Last Time — The Law That Governs Everything

Someone remind the room: what were the four types of people, and which one did 'Ali belong to?

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Example — Rumi’s raven and stork: A wise man discovers the secret bond between two unlike birds — both are lame in one leg.

Key Questions — Recap

- Q1. What is the universal law of attraction, and how did ancient people’s understanding differ from it?
- Q2. What are the four types of people, and which type does 'Ali belong to?
- Q3. Why is having strong attraction and repulsion not, by itself, proof of good character?

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Recap

Key Questions — Recap

Q: What is the universal law of attraction, and how did ancient people’s understanding differ from it?

A: Modern science holds that every atom in existence, from the smallest particle to the largest mass, is under a general law of attraction. Ancient people only recognised *particular* instances of it (e.g. magnet and iron, amber and straw) – they never grasped the universal principle behind them.

Q: What are the four types of people, and which type does 'Ali belong to?

A: (1) Attract nothing, repel nothing – like a slab of rock; (2) attract everyone, repel no one – usually hypocrisy, since real conviction always creates friction; (3) repel everyone, attract no one; (4) attract *and* repel – people of real conviction. 'Ali is Type 4, and his was the strongest example in history.

Q: Why is having strong attraction and repulsion not, by itself, proof of good character?

A: Strength of both powers only shows conviction, not virtue – what matters is *who* is drawn in and *who* is driven away. Even tyrants such as Genghis Khan, Hajjaj, and Mu’awiyah had both powers strongly.

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Q1. What is the universal law of attraction, and how did ancient people's understanding differ from it?

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Love and Hate Are Not Opposites — They’re One Faith

“Is belief anything but love and hate?”
— Imam al-Sadiq (a.s.), Al-Kāfi, Bk. 1, Ch. 60, Hadith 5

“The strongest ring of belief to hold onto... is love for the sake of Allah, hate for the sake of Allah.”
— The Prophet (s), Al-Kāfi, Bk. 1, Ch. 60, Hadith 6

- Faith made *beloved*. Disbelief made *hateful*. (Qur’an 49:7)
- Not prayer alone. Not fasting alone. Not hajj alone.
- Imam al-Baqir (a.s.): without love/hate on the basis of religion, one has, in effect, no religion.

Example — The companions guess: They suggest prayer, zakat, fasting, hajj, jihad – all wrong; the Prophet corrects them: it is love and hate for the sake of Allah.

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└ Opening

└ Love and Hate Are Not Opposites — They’re One Faith

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Example — The companions guess: They suggest prayer, zakat, fasting, hajj, jihad – all wrong; the Prophet corrects them: it is love and hate for the sake of Allah.

Show of hands: who has heard the phrase “love for the sake of Allah, hate for the sake of Allah” before tonight?

Key Questions — Opening Hadiths

- Q1. According to the hadith, what did Imam al-Sadiq say belief actually consists of?
- Q2. What did the Prophet identify as the strongest handhold of belief?

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The Power of Attraction in Imam Ali (A.S.)
└─ Opening
└─ Key Questions — Opening Hadiths

Q: According to the hadith, what did Imam al-Sadiq say belief actually consists of?
A: He said belief is nothing *but* love and hate – then recited Qur’an 49:7, where faith is made beloved to the heart and disbelief is made hateful to it.

Q: What did the Prophet identify as the strongest handhold of belief?
A: Not prayer, fasting, or hajj alone, but loving for the sake of Allah, hating for the sake of Allah, and aligning one’s loyalty and rejection accordingly.

Key Questions — Opening Hadiths

Q1. According to the hadith, what did Imam al-Sadiq say belief actually consists of?
Q2. What did the Prophet identify as the strongest handhold of belief?

A Call That Never Stopped Ringing

“Ali’s power of attraction was [three-dimensional]... not limited to one or two centuries.”

— Mutahhari

- One-dimensional → fades.
- Two-dimensional → lasts.
- Three-dimensional → reaches the depth of the heart — the mark of a prophet’s call

Example — Maytham at-Tammar: 20 years after 'Ali's death, under Umayyad repression, he praised 'Ali from his own cross – until he was gagged, then killed.

Example — Ibn as-Sikkit: ~200 years later, he told Caliph al-Mutawakkil that 'Ali's slave Qanbar was dearer to him than the caliph and his sons – and lost his tongue for it.

“If 'Ali had had no divine colouring... he would have been forgotten. He became more alive.”

— Mutahhari

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└ Powerful Attractions

└ A Call That Never Stopped Ringing

Guess: how many years after 'Ali's death did someone die for praising him publicly? (Twenty.)

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1D, 2D and 3D: The Reach of Attraction

1D: People	2D: People + Time	3D: People + Time + Depth
Elvis Presley	Socrates	Jesus Christ
Marilyn Monroe	Shakespeare	Buddha
Michael Jackson	Alexander the Great	Imam Hussain
Napoleon	Julius Caesar	Muhammad*
Steve Jobs	Leonardo da Vinci	Imam Ali
<i>Strong attraction</i>	<i>Enduring influence</i>	<i>Deep, enduring influence</i>

People → People + Time → People + Time + Depth

Illustrative examples – not Mutahhari’s own classification.

Where do Satan, Hitler, Rumi, Iqbal, Allama Majlisi, and Sheikh e Toosi fit?

Can we use Intensity (Sacrifice), Polarity (Attraction + Repulsion) to distinguish?

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Powerful Attractions

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Key Questions — Powerful Attractions

- Q1. What are the three “dimensions” of a call to humanity, and which does 'Ali's attraction belong to?
- Q2. How long after 'Ali's death did Maytham at-Tammar speak from his own crucifixion in praise of him?
- Q3. What did Ibn as-Sikkit say to Caliph al-Mutawakkil, and what did it cost him?
- Q4. What does Mutahhari mean when he says 'Ali “became more alive” after his death?

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└ Powerful Attractions

└ Key Questions — Powerful Attractions

Q: What are the three “dimensions” of a call to humanity, and which does 'Ali's attraction belong to?

A: One-dimensional calls spread widely, then fade. Two-dimensional calls spread widely *and* last through time. Three-dimensional calls spread widely, last through centuries, *and* penetrate the depth of the human heart – unique to the chain of the prophets. 'Ali's attraction belongs to this third, three-dimensional category.

Q: How long after 'Ali's death did Maytham at-Tammar speak from his own crucifixion in praise of him?

A: Twenty years, under brutal Umayyad repression – he was eventually gagged and executed for it.

Q: What did Ibn as-Sikkit say to Caliph al-Mutawakkil, and what did it cost him?

A: Asked whether his own sons were dearer to him than the caliph's, he said even 'Ali's slave Qanbar was dearer to him than the caliph and his sons – and had his tongue cut out for the answer.

Q: What does Mutahhari mean when he says 'Ali “became more alive” after his death?

A: Unlike other historical champions of speech, knowledge, or the battlefield – who are eventually forgotten – 'Ali's memory and influence only grew stronger after his martyrdom, because his link to people was not a material one but a bond of the spirit.

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Love That Survives the Sword

“One of the greatest marks of distinction of Shi’ism. . . is that its foundation and its bedrock is love.”

— Mutahhari

→ “Ali and his party will be the triumphant ones.” — the Prophet (s)

→ “The believer will never be your enemy, the hypocrite will never love you.”

“Ali is the standard and criterion for assaying human nature and temperaments.”

— Mutahhari

Example — The man whose hand was cut off: Punished justly by 'Ali, he still extols him at length to the Kharijite Ibn al-Kawwa': "Why should I not extol him, now that his friendship is mixed with flesh and blood?"

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└ Shi’ism, the Religion of Love

└ Love That Survives the Sword

Guess before the reveal: did the man curse 'Ali, stay silent, or praise him?

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Key Questions — Shi'ism, the Religion of Love

- Q1. What Prophetic statement does Mutahhari use to root Shi'ism in the principle of love?
- Q2. According to 'Ali's own words, why will a hypocrite never love him no matter what he does for them?
- Q3. What does the story of the man whose hand was cut off demonstrate about real love for 'Ali?
- Q4. In what sense does Mutahhari describe 'Ali as a "standard" or "criterion" for human nature?

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└ Shi'ism, the Religion of Love

└ Key Questions — Shi'ism, the Religion of Love

- Q: What Prophetic statement does Mutahhari use to root Shi'ism in the principle of love?
A: "'Ali and his party (Shi'ah) will be the triumphant ones" – from this he argues Shi'ism's foundation and bedrock is love and devotion to 'Ali.
- Q: According to 'Ali's own words, why will a hypocrite never love him no matter what he does for them?
A: He said that striking a true believer with his sword would never turn that believer into his enemy, and pouring the world's wealth on a hypocrite's head would never make the hypocrite love him – because, as the Prophet decreed, the believer will never be 'Ali's enemy and the hypocrite will never love him.
- Q: What does the story of the man whose hand was cut off demonstrate about real love for 'Ali?
A: That such love is rooted in truth and justice, not personal comfort or benefit – he was justly punished, yet still praised 'Ali at length because he recognised the punishment as rightly established by God.
- Q: In what sense does Mutahhari describe 'Ali as a "standard" or "criterion" for human nature?
A: A sound, pure nature will not turn against 'Ali even under his sword, while a diseased nature will show him no attachment even after receiving great favours – because 'Ali is nothing but the embodiment of truth itself.

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Love Is the Real Philosopher’s Stone

“Love, absolutely, is the “elixir”... which changes one nature into another.”

— Mutahhari

Copper into gold. Bitterness into sweetness.

“Love is the power of glory, it makes the coward courageous.”

— Mutahhari

Example — The hen: Timid and fleeing when alone – but with chicks to defend, she lowers her wings, attacks instead of fleeing.

“In the spirit, the effect of love is... development and thriving; in the body... melting and decomposition.”

— Mutahhari

Destroys the body. Perfects the spirit – removes envy, avarice, cowardice, laziness, self-admiration.

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└─ The Elixir of Love

└─ Love Is the Real Philosopher’s Stone

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Share, in a sentence: a time love (for a person, cause, or craft) made you braver or more disciplined than usual?

Key Questions — The Elixir of Love

- Q1. Where does the term “elixir” for love come from, and what did the alchemists originally mean by it?
- Q2. Describe the hen example – what does it illustrate about love’s effect on courage?
- Q3. What is the difference between love’s effect on the body versus its effect on the spirit?
- Q4. Name at least three negative qualities the text says love purifies from the spirit.

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└─ The Elixir of Love

└─ Key Questions — The Elixir of Love

Q: Where does the term “elixir” for love come from, and what did the alchemists originally mean by it?

A: Persian poets borrowed it from the alchemists, who believed in a mythical substance – also called the philosopher’s stone – capable of transmuting one material into another. The poets said love is the *real* elixir: people are like mines, and love is what refines them.

Q: Describe the hen example – what does it illustrate about love’s effect on courage?

A: Alone, a hen is timid, fleeing even from a child. Once she has chicks to defend, love transforms her: wings lowered for defence, clucking louder, attacking rather than fleeing – courage born from love, not personality.

Q: What is the difference between love’s effect on the body versus its effect on the spirit?

A: In the body, love’s effects can be destructive – pallor, sleeplessness, disorder in the digestive and nervous systems. In the spirit, it is purifying – it develops and perfects, turning bitterness sweet and copper to gold.

Q: Name at least three negative qualities the text says love purifies from the spirit.

A: Envy, avarice, cowardice, laziness, conceitedness, self-admiration, grudges, and malevolence.

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Love Is What Breaks You Out of Yourself

“Self-love is a limitation and a defensive barrier; love completely breaks down this defensive barrier.”

— Mutahhari

Timid. Cut off. Alone. — until love breaks the wall.

“The struggle with self-love is the struggle with the limitations of the self.”

— Mutahhari

→ Not less self — a *bigger* self

→ “The personality must expand to take in every other human being.”

“The reform of man does not lie in reducing him, it lies in perfecting and adding to him.”

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└ Breaking Down the Barriers

└ Love Is What Breaks You Out of Yourself

Clarify live: this isn’t about hating yourself – it’s expansion, not erasure.

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Key Questions — Breaking Down the Barriers

- Q1. What does Mutahhari mean by “self-love” as a “defensive barrier”?
- Q2. Does Mutahhari say the goal is to eliminate self-regard? What is the real goal instead?
- Q3. In his own words, what is the difference between “reducing” a person and “perfecting” a person?

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└ Breaking Down the Barriers

└ Key Questions — Breaking Down the Barriers

Q: What does Mutahhari mean by “self-love” as a “defensive barrier”?

A: As long as a person is locked inside self-love, they remain weak – timid, avaricious, quick-tempered, cut off from real vitality. Love breaks that barrier down, connecting the person to what is outside themselves.

Q: Does Mutahhari say the goal is to eliminate self-regard? What is the real goal instead?

A: No – eliminating legitimate self-regard (“amour-propre”) is not even coherent. The real goal is to *expand* the self so its boundary takes in other human beings, and ideally the whole of creation, rather than treating everything outside “me” as foreign.

Q: In his own words, what is the difference between “reducing” a person and “perfecting” a person?

A: Reform does not mean stripping away parts of a person’s existence – it lies in perfecting and adding to him, in growth and expansion, not in decrease or reduction.

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The Well That Never Runs Dry

“He is like the laws of nature which remain unchanged by time — a well-spring which is never dry, but which rather increases day by day.”
— Mutahhari, on 'Ali

- Love and hate: not a contradiction — a completed faith
- 'Ali: love strong enough to outlive centuries

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└─ Closing

└─ The Well That Never Runs Dry

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- Q1. What makes 'Ali's power of attraction “three-dimensional” rather than one- or two-dimensional?
- Q2. How does the story of the punished man (fingers cut off) prove that love for 'Ali isn't self-interested?
- Q3. What is the difference between love's effect on the body and its effect on the spirit?
- Q4. What does it mean to “expand the self” rather than eliminate self-love?
- Q5. Why does Mutahhari say 'Ali “became more alive” after his martyrdom rather than being forgotten?

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The Power of Attraction in Imam Ali (A.S.)

└ Closing

└ Key Questions — Full Session Review

Q: What makes 'Ali's power of attraction “three-dimensional” rather than one- or two-dimensional?

A: It spread widely across society, has lasted for centuries rather than fading, and penetrates to the depth of the human heart – a combination Mutahhari says is unique to the chain of the prophets.

Q: How does the story of the punished man (fingers cut off) prove that love for 'Ali isn't self-interested?

A: He had every material reason to resent 'Ali, yet praised him at length – showing his devotion was rooted in recognising truth and justice, not in personal comfort or favour.

Q: What is the difference between love's effect on the body and its effect on the spirit?

A: In the body it can be destructive (pallor, sleeplessness, disorder); in the spirit it is purifying and perfecting, removing envy, cowardice, laziness and self-admiration.

Q: What does it mean to “expand the self” rather than eliminate self-love?

A: Legitimate self-regard is not erased – instead, the boundary of “self” is pushed outward to include other people, and ideally all of creation, redirecting one's drives and affections beyond the self.

Q: Why does Mutahhari say 'Ali “became more alive” after his martyrdom rather than being forgotten?

A: Because his connection to people was not material but spiritual – unlike other historical champions who fade from memory, 'Ali's influence and remembrance have only grown across the centuries.

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Notice the Pattern

“He never just tells us love is powerful. He shows us a hen becoming brave. He never just tells us ‘Ali’s love was unique. He shows us a man losing his tongue for it.”

— The method of the whole talk

Claim → Story → Claim

Thank you.

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Quick Reference

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